Title: Scenography and national unity in ‘Soldaat van Oranje – De Musical’

Research question: How does ‘Soldaat van Oranje – De Musical’ use scenography to evoke the feeling of Dutch national unity and pride among the audience?

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Introduction

On October 30th 2010, 'Soldaat van Oranje – de Musical'[1] premiered in its specially designed and built TheaterHangaar at Valkenburg airfield in Katwijk. At the premier, Queen Beatrix der Nederlanden, the monarch of the Netherlands at the time, was present. The plot of the musical is based on Erik Hazelhoff Roelfzema's, historically referred to as the Soldier of Orange, real life story. The musical follows him and his friends from the university of Leiden throughout the Second World War. All having different lifepaths due to certain choices they make: Erik escapes Nazi-occupied Netherlands to ask the queen's help with the resistance, whereas his best friend, Anton, choses for the side of the Nazi's and joins the SS. By now, the musical has been running for eleven years, with more than 2800 performances, and more than 3.2 million visitors ('Information about the Dutch production'). The last award received was right before the COVID-19 pandemic on the 22nd of January 2020, winning the unique achievement musical award, an award implemented uniquely for this musical ('Soldaat van Oranje ontvangt unieke musicalprijs'). Besides, Soldaat van Oranje is also the longest running musical in the Netherlands, still being sold-out every evening. Keeping all of the above in mind, one could argue that this musical has certainly left its mark on the history of theatre in the Netherlands. An explanation on why this show has been running for so long, has been provided in an interview with Theu Boermans, director of the musical, in which he dedicates the success of the musical to his belief that the Dutch would like to consider themselves as an authentic nation-state and that this musical conveys a sense of national unity and pride. Boermans claims that the Netherlands can almost be considered as a province of Germany due to homogeneity of Dutch and German culture. He signalises this as a cause for such desire for authenticity and distinction among the Dutch. (Bone en Mulder, 204-205).

[1] 'Soldier of Orange – the Musical'

This essay will bring an answer to the question of ***how 'Soldaat van Oranje – De Musical' uses scenography to evoke the feeling of Dutch national unity and pride among the audience.*** Nowadays, scenography is considered to be one of the key components in theatre. Especially in this production, scenography plays an prominent role, as the scenography influences the audience's view on the characters and their lives to such an extent that the audience holds a biased view at the end of the musical, whereas the text does not have a clear bias. In order to write this essay, I have visited the musical on the 13th of April 2022, meaning that in this essay, the scenography used at the time will be taken into consideration. This essay shall first discuss what scenography and national identity means and how national identity is perceived to be from the Dutch. Through analysis of the scenography, this essay shall then discuss particular moments in the performance through the scenography in place and the impact the usage of such has on the audience. Eventually, both parts shall be combined into answering the research question of this essay. This essay shall argue that in 'Soldaat van Oranje – De Musical', the scenography influences the perspective of the audience on the characters and the choices they make, through villainizing the Germans and glorifying the Dutch. Due to utilization of national iconography, identification with characters is made about national identity, resulting in the audience experiencing a sense of Dutch national unity.

National identity and identification

The story of Soldaat van Oranje takes place during the second world war, in which Nazi-Germany fell into neighbouring countries to expand its territory and fulfil the Nazi-ideology of exterminating the 'Untermensch'. In the musical, the invasion of the Netherlands is considered to be an attack on the Dutch fatherland, constructing the idea that the occupation of the Netherlands was a combat ought to be fought by the Dutch resistance against the Nazis. Thus, the musical focusses on the national identity of the characters.

The concept of national identity however was only established in 1648 with the Treaty of Westphalia, signed to end the 30 year war in (north-) west Europe. This treaty created states based upon a cohesive identity within territorial borders, resulting in identity becoming the basis of modern society (Abdulsattar). Nowadays, societies are based upon identity to such an extent that many scholars argue that identity is partially formed through nationhood. For example, Geoffrey Cubitt, author of the book 'Imagining Nations', emphasises that "we live in a nationalised world. The concept of nation is central to the dominant understanding both of political community and of personal identity" (qtd. In Edensor, 24). Due to this "nationalised world", people tend to give meaning to the phenomenon of national identity. According to Stephen Shulman, associate professor in international relations and ethnic politics at Southern Illinois University, the term national identity refers to "the traits that simultaneously unify people into a nation and distinguish them from other nations" (Shulman, 35). He claims that in all nations, one can identify a qualitative and a quantitative component. In this essay, the focus will be on this qualitative component. Shulman defines this as "the reasons why people in a nation-state feel they form a community" (Shulman, 35). However, in order for people to unify, identification must occur. Tim Edensor, professor in cultural geography at Manchester Metropolitan University, argues that "A key element of the process of identification – especially in the case of national identity – […] is the drawing of boundaries between self and 'other'" (Edensor, 24). The main reason for identification with a community or nation, has to do with memory. Memory refers to "the faculty that enables us to form an awareness of selfhood (identity), both on the personal and on the collective level" (Young et al., 109-118). According to Sara Young, author of "a companion to cultural memory studies", cultural memory refers to the interplay of present and past in socio-cultural context. Even today, scholars disagree on whether cultural memory is different from collective memory. However, Jan Assmann, professor in Egyptology at Heidelberg

University, argued that cultural memory does differ from collective memory, as collective memory is short term, usually up to three generations, and diffused by communication, whereas cultural memory requires institutions of preservation and embodiment and a longer lasting time of influence on remembrance culture (Young et al., 109-118). Cultural memory thus has, like other forms of memories, important influence on identity and group forming, strengthening a form of shared identity (National Geographic Society).

According to Stuart Hall, cultural theorist and sociologist, "National cultures are composed not only of cultural institutions, but of symbols and representations. A national culture is a discourse – a way of constructing meanings which influences and organizes both our actions and our conception of ourselves (…). National cultures construct identities by producing meanings about 'the nation' with which we can identify; these are contained in the stories which are told about it, memories which connect its present with its past, and images which are constructed of it." (qtd. In Minnaard, 15). However, when one tries to capture one's national identity and explains this to others coming from different backgrounds and national cultures, one tends to reduce its national culture to popular or exemplar cultural icons. These icons develop into a nations iconography and can therefore be used in theatre (Holdsworth, 55).

Scenography and iconography

Where and when theatre as an autonomous form, without serving a religious purpose, originated, remains unclear. Nevertheless, what is certain is that Tragedy, an Ancient Greek style of theatre, utilized scenography in order to convey its message. At the time, scenography was referred to as spectacle, spectacle including anything the audience is able to see on stage, including set, costume and props (Aristotle, 9-10). Aristotle argued that spectacle is the least artistic form of all the parts of emotional attraction, since it has almost to no connection to the art of the poet, the playwright of the piece. Nowadays, in modern theatre, spectacle, better

known as scenography, is seen as one of the crucial parts of theatre. According to Joslin McKinney and Butterworth, associate professor in scenography and reader in medieval theatre at the University of Leeds, respectively, 'scenography' refers to "the manipulation and orchestration of the performance environment" (Mckinney and Butterworth, ii). They claim that "settings and structures, light, projected images, sound, costumes and props" are considered forms of scenography. Their approach focus solely on the physical and materialistic environment the performer is in on stage. Some academicians however, argue that scenography can also be used to influence the audience's perspective on characters. According to Rachel Hann, cultural scenographer and author of the book 'Beyond Scenography', "stage and scene and the aesthetic ideology of 'the scenic'" have a symbiotic relationship. She emphasizes that "there is no theatre practice without scenography" (Hann, i). In her book, Hann defines scenography as a crafting of place orientation, signifying her perception of scenography as the crafting of the position of the performer in relation to its surroundings. Meaning that the place where the performer seems to be in the story, mentally, emotionally, and physically, is created through scenography. Therefore, scenography is a mean to communicate the story of the play and is a tool that can be used by a director to achieve their intended impact, resulting in scenography being crucial for theatrical storytelling.

Within scenography, iconography is a tool used by directors to convey a certain message to the audience. Heck, author of the book "Picturing Performance: The Iconography of the Performing Arts in Concept and Practice", defines iconography as "the study of subject matter and meaning in works of art and, as a corollary, the study of signs and symbols in art." (Heck et al, xii). In scenography, all production elements contribute to the way the audience interprets or constructs meaning from the performance. All production elements convey meaning to the audience and thus contribute to the audience's experience of the story

portrayed. Hence, the director should constantly keep the impact their chosen production element has on the audience in mind, as their chosen production element has a specific iconographic meaning.

Due to the influence scenography and iconography have on the perspective conveyed to the audience, directors have direct influence on how the audience experiences certain moments and/or characters in a play. In Soldaat van Oranje, national iconography is incorporated in the scenography of the musical. Therefore manipulating the audience into having a certain perspective.

Scenography in Soldaat van Oranje and its impact on the audience

The main theme of Soldaat van Oranje – the Musical is 'making choices'. This theme is presented throughout the musical, the audience is supposed to ask themselves what they would do if they would have been in a situation as depicted on stage. Hence, throughout the play, the audience gets to see the development of most characters, so that the audience will be able to make a balanced choice at the end of the musical. However, the scenography of the play can be considered biased, as the scenography seems to villainise the SS and Nazi-Germany while glorify the Dutch resistance and the Netherlands, resulting in the audience being influenced in their reasoning about which choices they would make. This claim is supported by research done by Laurie Slegtenhorst, historian specialised in contemporary popularization of WWII, on with whom of the characters the audience would identify themselves. Only a total of 3% would identify themselves with the people that joined the SS, compared to 54% of the responders identifying themselves with the other characters that did not join the SS or even joined the resistance afterwards. In an interview done by Slegtenhorst

a man answered that he experienced "Sympathy for the characters turned against the Nazis and antipathy for the Nazis and those who joined or supported them"[2] (Slegtenhorst, 80).

Villainization of the Germans

The villainization of the Germans through scenography is continuous throughout the musical, resulting in the audience having a biased perspective on the Nazis. The first time the characters in the musical get confronted with the war is when their sorority party gets abruptly disturbed by someone running in and turning on the radio. The sorority party takes place in the sorority house. The background of the stage are the walls of the sorority ballroom, made out of wooden panels with white text – the names of past graduates – with on stage right a big portrait of Queen Wilhelmina and a big banner hanging from the wall. The men are in full gala suit and the women are wearing dresses with flower patterns, of which some have tulips, and elegant heels. The lights are dark blue with yellow light coming from the front, creating a warm colour on the characters. There's live music playing, with an up-beat tempo and the sound of several wind instruments. The incorporated Dutch iconography in the scenography of this moment, the tulip patterns and the portrait of the Dutch queen, and the festive atmosphere that is created through the lights, music and costumes evoke a positive feeling with the audience. However, after someone runs in and turns off the music and turns on the radio, the point from which the yellow light comes, lowers, creating long shadows on stage. All the festive music stops and the only sound is the voice of the queen coming from the radio. On top of that, there's a spotlight on the two main characters of the play: Erik, the Dutch protagonist, and Anton, the German antagonist. Immediately, the atmosphere on stage changes from positive and festive into negative and frightened and the long shadows on stage create an ominous feeling among the audience. Due to the remembrance culture in the Netherlands about WWII, the audience already knows what the queen's message would be

[2] Translated by student: "Sympathie voor de personages zich tegen de Nazi's keerden en antipathie tegen de Nazi's en degenen die zich hierbij aansloten of ondersteunden".

and therefore associates this frightened and ominous feeling with the arrival of the Germans in the Netherlands. The association is further emphasized by the spotlight on Erik and Anton, as this puts the focus on the different national identities of the two main characters. Thus, the musical proposes that the contrast in atmosphere on stage, evoked through changes in scenography, is caused by the invasion by the Germans. Therefore, villainizing the Nazi-Germans.

Other times, the villainization of the Germans is expressed through visualization of the Germans in the musical and the changes in scenography on stage. The visualization of the Germans and villainization that's incorporated within, becomes evident through the development in appearance of Anton and his girlfriend, Ada. During the opening scenes, the character appearance of Anton and Ada is the same as the other students. The women are dressed in light colours and floral prints and the men in white shirts, suspenders and blue or brown pants. However, after Anton and Ada joined the SS, they only wear the SS uniform. Anton's character design changed into a complete black suit, with leather boots, metal chains over his shoulder and a red arm-tie with a swastika – to symbolize Nazism. He also wears a weapon belt around his waist. His hair got a tighter parting and more gel. Ada's character design changes too: her make-up used to look natural, but after joining the SS, she wears thick black eyeliner and clear red lipstick. Her costume also changes into leather shoes, high black stockings, a grey skirt, white blouse and a black tie. Her hair is pinned tightly to the head. These adjustments in the character design of Anton and Ada make them appear strict and aggressive. According to Iris Matters, expert in contemporary theatre and dance dramaturgy, this transformation creates an "us versus them" situation, especially considering the contrast that's created through the character design of Charlotte, a female character that joins the Dutch resistance (13-14). Charlotte's appearance stays the same, light-coloured and floral dresses with soft curls falling onto her shoulders. Hence, the development and contrast in

character design between the characters that fight for Dutch liberty and the characters that join the SS, and therefore cooperate with the Germans, emphasizes the aggressive appearance of the Germans in the musical. Thus, the changes in scenography villainize the Germans.

Glorification of the Dutch

Whereas the scenography of the musical tends to villainize the Germans throughout the musical, the scenography also proposes the Dutch, especially those joining the resistance, as heroic fighters for liberty, therefore glorifying the Dutch. The shaping of perspective through scenography starts even before the musical does. Namely, The foyer in the TheaterHangaar is decorated with a multitude of propositions, that can be regarded as Dutch iconography. The foyer is coloured in white and orange. White is usually considered as the colour of goodness and orange the colour of success (Van Braam). Besides, orange is also the national colour of the Netherlands. Hence, the iconography in colour suggests a positive attitude towards the Dutch, utilizing iconography to initiate identification among the audience with their national identity. This claim is supported by research done by Andrew J. Elliot and Markus A. Maier, professors of psychology at the university of Rochester and Munich, respectively. They argue that "the evaluative processes evoked by color stimuli produce motivated behavior. Color stimuli that carry a positive meaning produce approach responses, whereas those that carry a negative meaning produce avoidance responses." (251). In addition, all across TheaterHangaar, excerpts of stories about the second world war are written on the walls. One quote states: "Het waren de dingen die de Duitsers deden en toen die ons persoonlijk begonnen te raken ontstond het punt waarop de beslissing viel of je de kant op ging of de andere."[3]. Such texts symbolize the main theme of the musical. Due to the colours of the walls, these texts influence the audience in their position on which choices are considered right and wrong. Whilst due to the mentioning of the Germans, the audience takes

[3] Translated by student: "It was the things the Germans did and when they started to affect us personally the point got reached where the decision was made whether to go one way or the other."

their national identity into account. Hence, the combination of text and colour glorifies the Dutch, producing a positive attitude towards the audience's national identity. On top of that, next to the entrance, there's a V-shaped monument display case, filled with several items associated with the ostensible Victory of the Dutch over the Germans: important military medals, fake identity cards used by people from the Dutch resistance, and written letters and signed photos of Dutch soldiers. Some of the items displayed hold iconographic meaning for the Dutch, such as the Willems-Orde medal, the oldest and highest military distinction of the Kingdom of the Netherlands. All items however glorify the Dutch during WWII, as the items convey the bravery and patriotism of the Dutch. Therefore, one could argue that the audience's perspective is shaped in favour of the Dutch prior to the musical and that due to the distinction that's made between the Dutch and the Germans through the scenography of the foyer, the scenography glorifies the Dutch. Besides, these items recall cultural memory among the audience, as these items have developed meaning for the Dutch as a symbol for the Dutch resistance and the fight for Dutch liberty and sovereignty. Thus, this cultural memory strengthens the sense of a shared national identity, reemphasizing the contrast between the villainized Germans and the glorified Dutch



Figure 1: arrival queen Wilhelmina at Gilze-Rijen, recreated in the musical (Photo: Jan van Bennekom)

In the musical, the Dutch also tend to be glorified through the bias in scenography. After the war has ended and the Netherlands is liberated from the Germans, the queen, who fled to England to stay saver, returns to the fatherland. As can be seen in figure 1, the doors at the back of the stage are opened and the audience can see the outside of the TheaterHangaar. A real Dakota from 1937 drives into vision and the audience feels the wind coming from it, creating a feeling as if the audience was there at the time. The Dakota is painted alike the Dakota used in 1945. On stage, as the queen steps out of the plane, the people around start waving the Dutch flag and start signing the Wilhelmus, the Dutch National Anthem. The queen is dressed in a long grey jacket with a raccoon around her neck as a scarf. The raccoon symbolizes the characteristics shown by the Dutch resistance during WWII and shows her support to the resistance: intelligence, bravery, slyness and self-defending. The other women on stage are dressed with jackets in the colours of the Dutch flag (red, white, blue) and the national colour (orange). The scenography creates a victorious atmosphere on stage and thus glorifies the Dutch, as this scenography symbolizes the transition back to the situation as it was before the war, with the Dutch living in liberty and sovereignty. On top of that, the scenography in this scene also has an imposing effect on the audience, influencing the audience's perspective on the Dutch as powerful and brave. In this scene, the nation's flags, the national anthem, and the colours of the jackets can be considered as national icons, creating identification based on national identity among the audience. Hence, this scenography proposes the idea that the Dutch have won the war from the Germans, glorifying the Dutch as the victors' of WWII.

Conclusion

Through the use of scenography in the play, audiences of Soldaat van Oranje are introduced to a version of a story that is largely biased towards the Dutch nation. In order to evoke such bias, the director utilizes contrasts in scenography. With dichotomies in

atmospheres, character designs, propositions, etc., the scenography generally villainizes the Germans, whilst glorifying the Dutch. Thus, the scenography draws boundaries between the self and the 'other', initiating identification among the audience. As the scenography contains Dutch national iconography, identification with the nation is supported. On top of that, the usage of such national iconography recalls cultural memory, further strengthening a form of shared identity. Therefore, the musical utilizes scenography to evoke the sense of Dutch national unity and ardent pride for the audience's (Dutch) national identity.

This result that the musical has on the audience, a sense of national unity and pride, corresponds with Theu Boermans' idea on why the musical has been so successful in the Netherlands. Namely, the audience's longing for the Netherlands being considered an authentic nation-state, distinct from the German nation.

In the current global political state, the power and sovereignty of the nation-state is challenged through diverse Non-State Actors. Hence, the importance of a strong and clear sense of national identity and national pride increases for nation-states if they want to maintain the most important actors on a global scale. Therefore, this musical makes a clear example of how theatre can used be a mean to enhance such feeling of national unity and national pride.

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